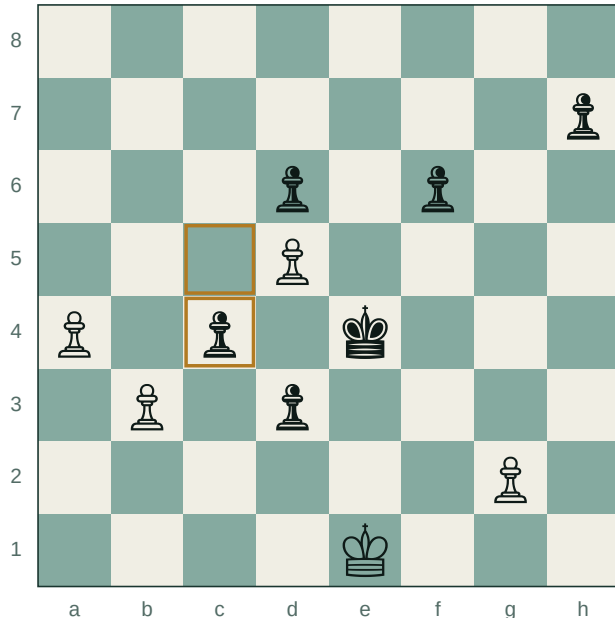


Pawn-ending calculation: White, move 38

Pawn-ending calculation

White to move



Previous move: 37...c4. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

38. bxc4 Kd4 39. a5 Kxc4 40. a6 Kxd5 41. a7

38.bxc4 The pawn captures the pawn on c4. Recorded reply: **38...Kd4**.

39.a5 The pawn moves from a4 to a5. Recorded reply: **39...Kxc4**.

40.a6 The pawn moves from a5 to a6. Recorded reply: **40...Kxd5**.

41.a7 The pawn moves from a6 to a7.

At the end, nominal material is White 2 / Black 4 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by -1. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** -1: the balance goes from -1 to -2. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Do not enter a pawn ending because it looks simple. Rook-pawn exceptions and zugzwang can make a material advantage irrelevant.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

With only kings and pawns, a single tempo can reverse the result. Calculate opposition, capture routes, promotion races, and reserve pawn moves precisely.

HOW TO LOOK

Count actual king moves and pawn pushes, then include whose turn it is and whether promotion gives check.

The defending king is on e4. Look for a defender that can be displaced or overloaded.